All this context can be used to inform access decisions. Thus, establishing that the original enrollee is the current requester is vital to making correct authorization decisions.

WHAT IS DEVICE POSTURE?

Device posture refers to the current trustworthiness of the device involved in an authentication or access request. Device posture is not just a single signal or a fixed property; it is a combined assessment based on multiple device-related attributes evaluated at the moment of access. These attributes typically answer questions like these:

- Is the device managed by the organization?
- Is it compliant with required security controls (OS version, encryption, screen lock)?
- Is it healthy (not jailbroken, rooted, or reporting malware)?
- Is it connecting from an expected environment (network, geography, time)?
- Is its security state recently attested, or is the information stale?

In zero-trust architectures, device posture is considered a primary context signal. Authentication not only confirms who is making a request but also assesses the device and the conditions. A valid identity from a non-compliant or unknown device may authenticate successfully but can still be denied access to sensitive resources.

Throughout this book, when we refer to policies that require a managed, trusted, or healthy device, we rely on device posture as an input signal. The specific signals and thresholds are determined by each organization, but the core idea remains the same: Access decisions depend on not only identity but also the state of the device asserting that identity.